

Indira’s grandparents, parents, aunts, uncles and cousins were all active in the nationalist movement and she too was drawn into it. At four, she sat on her grandfather’s lap during his trial (Motilal Nehru was arrested by the British for organizing a hartal). At twelve, she helped found the Vanar Sena, a Congress children’s group that was active in the 1930s. At university in England, she campaigned to gain public support for the movement.

Democracy and dissent

During her first full term as prime minister, Indira implemented populist measures that had faced opposition from her former party colleagues. She also altered the character of the central government, the bureaucracy and the judiciary by centralizing power in the hands of the prime minister and preferentially appointing her supporters (often friends and family members) to high positions. This inevitably led to corruption and nepotism, and rising prices and food shortages after successive failed monsoons created public discontent. The public’s dissatisfaction manifested in a popular movement against the Congress in 1974. Led by Jayaprakash Narayan, the goal of the movement was the removal of Indira Gandhi and the corrupt Congress, and a ‘total revolution’ in Indian society and politics.

A state of emergency